Negatives, hedging and certainty

Understand it

Academic writers rarely claim that something is 100% true. They hedge: they use words that show how certain they are. In Reading, hedging decides True / False / Not Given; in Writing and Speaking, it makes your opinions sound careful and mature.

There are several kinds of hedging: modal verbs, adverbs of certainty, verbs of seeming, quantity words and impersonal phrases. Learn the strength of each one.

The rules

- Negatives are not only not: hardly, rarely, seldom, barely, scarcely, little, few, no, none, never, neither. Few students passed = almost nobody passed.
- Certainty words: certainly, definitely (100%), probably, likely (70%), possibly, may, might, could (30%).
- Hedging verbs: suggest, seem, appear, tend to. The study suggests that = it is not proven.
- In True / False / Not Given: Some = not all; All = every one; Most = more than half; Only = nothing else.

All the words and forms you need

Modal verbs (strong to weak)	will · must · should · would · can · could · may · might
Adverbs of certainty	certainly · definitely · undoubtedly · clearly · probably · likely · arguably · possibly · perhaps · apparently · presumably
Verbs of seeming	seem to · appear to · tend to · suggest · indicate · imply
Adjectives	likely · unlikely · possible · probable · potential
Quantity / frequency hedges	some · many · most · often · usually · generally · in most cases · to some extent · in some ways
Impersonal phrases	It is possible that · There is evidence that · It is widely believed that · It could be argued that · Research suggests that
Negatives that are not 'not'	hardly · barely · scarcely · rarely · seldom · few · little · no longer

Where you use it

Reading: If the text says may and the question says will, the answer is usually Not Given or False.

Listening: Speakers hedge with I suppose, probably, it looks like.

Writing: Use hedging in opinions: This may lead to ...

Speaking: Use I suppose, I guess, probably to sound natural.

More examples

- The results suggest that sleep may improve memory.
- Social media tends to make teenagers more anxious.
- It is likely that prices will rise next year.
- Few students passed the exam (= almost nobody).
- This could arguably be the most important invention of the century.
- In most cases, early treatment is successful.

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ Few students passed, so most passed.	✓ Few means almost nobody: most did not pass.
✗ The text says may, so I answered True for will.	✓ May is not the same as will.
✗ Only means the same as mainly.	✓ Only excludes everything else.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Will people still read books in 50 years? (use probably / might)
2. Are young people today happier than their parents were? (use tend to)
3. Is it good for children to learn two languages? (use it seems that)
4. Will robots replace teachers? (use unlikely)
5. Is social media good for friendships? (use to some extent)

Writing practice

Make these sentences more careful: Phones destroy children's concentration. Everyone prefers online shopping. Cars will disappear from cities.

Practice

1. Which is stronger: might / must?

2. Does Few students passed mean many or almost nobody?

3. Text: Exercise can reduce stress. Statement: Exercise always reduces stress. T / F / NG?

4. Text: Most farmers use machines. Statement: All farmers use machines.

5. Text: The drug may help. Statement: The drug helps.

6. Rank: certainly, possibly, probably.

Answers

1. must
2. almost nobody
3. False (can not always)
4. False
5. Not Given (the text only says may)
6. certainly > probably > possibly